

» VIJAY HAZARE TROPHY



Long awaited: Denied in 2024–25, Vidarbha returned stronger, outscoring Saurashtra in a high-octane final to seal its maiden Vijay Hazare Trophy title. K. MURALIKUMAR

VIDARBHA'S CROWN, AND EARLY SIGNPOSTS ON INDIA'S ROAD TO 2027

Vidarbha's maiden Vijay Hazare Trophy title capped a **revived domestic season** that quietly offered early clues about India's ODI direction towards 2027.

Anish Pathiyil and Shayan Acharya

anish.p@thehindu.co.in, shayan.acharya@thehindu.co.in

A fair fight between bat and ball, youngsters stepping up on the big stage and Indian cricket's corps d'elite briefly rediscovering their aura: the Vijay Hazare Trophy (VHT) 2025–26 offered evidence that there is some life left in a format long labelled travail. At its heart lay the emergence of a first-time champion in Vidarbha.

The team from southern Maharashtra has emerged as a formidable force in red-ball cricket, winning three Ranji Trophy titles in the last eight years. It came close to a

maiden white-ball crown in 2025, led by skipper Karun Nair's 779-run season, but fell short at the final hurdle against Mayank Agarwal's Karnataka.

Despite Nair moving back to his home State ahead of the current season, his absence was scarcely felt, thanks to Aman Mokhadé's dominant tournament with the bat. The 25-year-old, who trained under Jwala Singh, the noted Mumbai coach who also mentored Yashasvi Jaiswal, accumulated 814 runs in 10 matches, including five centuries, and finished just 16 runs shy of N. Jagadeesan's

all-time season record.

Pacers Yash Thakur and Nachiket Bhute were the team's main strikers with the ball, picking up 19 and 18 wickets, respectively. The mantle of captaincy was taken up by young all-rounder Harsh Dubey, who became the first captain to guide Vidarbha to a white-ball title.

Vidarbha's opponent in the summit clash was also led by a rookie skipper in wicketkeeper Harvik Desai. The 26-year-old led the scoring charts for Saurashtra, amassing 581 runs at an average of 64.55. His opening partner, Vishvaraj Jadeja, also contributed three hundreds, including an unbeaten 165 in the semifinal against Punjab. Ankur